The sixth extinction

Some ecologists have estimated the current rate of extinction of animals and plants at 1,000–10,000 times the natural background rate, with most of the increase due directly or indirectly to human activities. They argue that this is evidence the world is already in the middle of the Holocene extinction, named for the present geological epoch. Many species of animals and plants have been lost since the start of the Industrial Revolution in the 18th century. These losses have been driven by habitat change, climate change, overfishing, overhunting, ocean acidification, air pollution, and the introduction of animals that disrupt food chains. American ecologist E.O. Wilson, known as “the father of biodiversity,” believes that if the species die-off continues at the present rate, half of all higher life forms will be extinct by 2100. Stuart Pimm, a British–American biologist and modern extinctions expert, is more cautious, claiming that we are on the cusp of such an event and can still act to stop it.